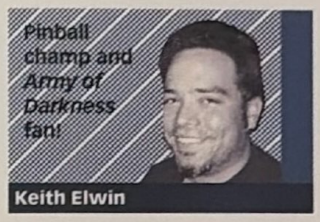
HOW TO...

Buy a Pinball Machine

As the International Flipper Pinball Association's top-ranked player, Keith Elwin owns the silver ball. Here's how you can, too.


Pinball champ and *Army of Darkness* fan!

Keith Elwin

1 Waste quarters first
Buying a pinball machine is like buying a car—you've got a ton to choose from, so test-drive as many as possible and don't buy anything until you've spent some time behind the flippers. It's also good to check the Internet Pinball Machine Database (IPDB.org) for specs and info.

2 Played-out proofing
No matter what, get a machine that challenges you. A few of my favorites are Flash Gordon, Safe Cracker, Bram Stoker's Dracula, Mystic, and Dr. Who. These games may not be extremely collectible or difficult to find, but they're all "player's games," and they'll keep you entertained. Now you just have to focus on not spraining your wrists.

3 Check under the hood
Brighter colors such as red, orange, and yellow can fade if the previous owner kept the machine too close to a window, so eyeball the artwork carefully. Open up the coin box and take a whiff, too—if it smells like an ashtray, it probably lived in a smoky bar for years. This could make your game room stink...or fit right in.

GO BALLS OUT!
Check out IFPApinball.com for a tournament near you and flip with the pros.

4 My generation...or my old man's?
There are two basic machine types: pre-1978 electromechanical machines with ringing chimes and scoring reels that spin, and post-1979 solid-state rigs with digital displays and soundboards. Older games break often, but repairs are easy. Modern games are durable, but a bitch to fix.

5 Flashy feng shui
Put some thought into your setup. These machines are only about three feet wide, but you'll need 13 total feet in length (eight for the game, three to stand and play, and two more in case you ever need to remove the glass). Since the general illumination, or "GI," features are part of what makes pinball cool, a room with minimal overhead lighting is key.

BALL HOG

Holy Rails

Buy these sick rigs on Classicpinball.com.

1 **Medieval Madness** ($7,000 and up)
2 **Cactus Canyon** ($7,000 and up)
3 **The Addams Family** ($4,000 and up)
4 **Indiana Jones: The Pinball Adventure** ($3,500 and up)
5 **Flash Gordon** ($2,500 and up)
6 **Fireball** ($2,500 and up)

Text, Jeff Foss; photograph, David Arky